



NJALA UNIVERSITY

ADDRESS

By

Professor Bashiru Mohamed Koroma, Ph. D.

Vice-Chancellor and Principal

Njala University

at the

2025 Congregation Ceremony

for the Conferment of Degrees, and Awards of Diplomas and Certificates,

***Theme: Turning Resources into Results and Accelerating Digital Learning in
Njala University***

Venue: Forecourt of the Administrative Building, Njala Campus, Njala.

Date: Friday 21st February 2025

Salutations

- Chancellor and Chairman of Court
- His Excellency the President, Commander-in-Chief of the Armed Forces of the Republic of Sierra Leone, and Visitor of Njala University
- Hon Vice President of the Republic of Sierra Leone
- Hon Chief Minister of the Republic of Sierra Leone
- Minister of Technical and Higher Education
- Other Ministers and Deputy Ministers of Government here present
- Members of the Njala University Court
- Vice-Chancellors and Principals of USL, EBKUST, ETU-SL, MMTU and KUST
- Vice- Chancellors and Principals of Private Universities and other Tertiary Institutions
- Deputy Vice-Chancellors of Njala University and other Universities present here
- Excellences, Members of the Diplomatic & Consular Corps
- Our Revered Paramount Chiefs and other Traditional Rulers
- Your Worships the Mayors of the cities of Bo, Bonthe, Makeni, Freetown, and Kenema.
- Hon. Members of Parliament
- The Chairpersons and Members of the Moyamba, Bo, Pujehun and Bonthe District Councils
- Representatives of International Organizations and Agencies
- Our Development Partners
- Alumni of Njala University
- Representatives of Civil Society Organizations
- All Staff and Students of Njala University
- All citizens of the Republic of Sierra Leone present here and all of you following this event remotely or otherwise
- Members of the Fourth Estate
- Distinguished Guests
- Ladies and Gentlemen

1. We are most delighted as members of the Njala University Family to welcome you all to join us this morning for our 16th Congregation ceremony this year, for the conferment of Undergraduate Degrees, Diplomas and Certificates.
2. Mr. Chancellor, Sir, this celebration is another milestone in annals of our history - for the graduands, their families, friends, and the well-wishers, for us as a university, and, indeed, for Sierra Leone as a nation. Let me take this opportunity to welcome, and offer a special thank you to the parents, guardians and sponsors who have joined us today to celebrate these achievements. Thank you all for being here today.
3. Mr. Chancellor, Sir, I am pleased to announce that today, we shall be witnessing the award of a total of **1,479 Undergraduate Degrees**, of which **926** are males and **553 females** and a total of **813 Diplomas and Certificates** of which 320 are males and **493** are females. **Congratulations. Let us give ourselves a round of applause.** We are hopeful that these students will be able to use the skills acquired, continue to learn to improve themselves and serve their communities and country as well. Let me also most sincerely thank the members of the Senate and Court, as well as the Administrative and Academic staff for their continued guidance and support for these achievements.
4. Mr. Chancellor Sir, we have procured solar-mini grid of 100 kilowatts to provide electricity for the Faculty Building (now John Abu Kamara Building) and the Auditorium from our own source of revenue to obviate one of the major challenges of inadequate supply of electricity at the main Njala Campus. This has significantly benefitted the Postgraduate and Undergraduate Students in Njala Campus, including staff of various categories, and the supply of electricity in these buildings has been regular and awaiting commissioning.

5. **Solar training for staff:** Mr. Chancellor, Sir, Ekhlis Solar Electrical and Installation Company has provided an up-to-date solar training at Towama for six (6) months. The company also donated ten solar streetlights to Bo Campus on 24th October 2024 - The training has drawn 80 trainees, including 20 Njala University staff members at the cost of Le 6,000 per staff to the sum of Le 60,000, and 60 community members, who have completed the competency-based training. Of the 80 trainees, 20 are females. The training focused primarily on hands-on skills, with 80% of the assessment being practical and 20% theoretical. The final assessments will be overseen by Njala University Board of Trustees to ensure quality. The Njala University will conduct the certification ceremony by April 2025.
6. Also, Mr. Chancellor, we are providing colossal amounts yearly in Tuition Waivers to staff and children of staff; supported staff on study leave both within and without the country and provided 0% loan interest to staff. All these are geared towards settling these staff in a policy to redirect staff attention to the workings of the University.

Below is table 1 for payment made in the respective categories as tuition waivers to staff, spouses, and children, as well as children of communities in our operational Districts.

Table 1: Summary of Tuition Waivers for 2024/2025 Academic Year

Category	No. of Staff	Student	Total	Total Amount
Postgraduate	4	14	18	717,188.00
Undergraduate	12	97	109	835,090.00
Community		62	62	408,395.00
Grand Total	16	173	127	1,960,673.00

7. **Research Grants from Source Revenue:** Mr. Chancellor, Sir, at the 18th March, 2023 congregation last year, the University set aside in the 2022-2023 budget, the sum of Le 500,000 to fund staff research activities in the University. I am happy to report to this floor of congregation that the said Le 500,000 resource was almost exhausted by significantly turning that

resource into remarkable results as shown in table 2 below. The University provided this basic support that enhanced grant proposal writing skills on winnable projects. In that light, some academic staff and their students benefited significantly. This is in acknowledgement that a university becomes relevant only when it contributes immensely to the advancement of knowledge.

Table 2: Breakdown of Beneficiaries of the Grant Awards

Beneficiary	Research Type	Total Amount (Le)
. Prof Alie Mohamed Bah	Rice Brand Publication	12,500
. Prof Philip Foday Yamba Thullah	Research on Local Music	120,000
. Mr. Claude Dimoh	INSLACS Week	134,000
. School Technology	New Varietal Rice Production and Distribution to Farmers	120,000
. Animal Science	Artificial Insemination	97,000
Total		484,003

8. **Research on Sierra Leone’s Traditional Musicians:** Mr. Chancellor, Sir, The Institute of Languages and Cultural Studies (INSLACS) conducted a project to document the practices, challenges, and cultural significance of Sierra Leone's traditional musicians. The project included a biography book, articles, and a documentary film, providing accessible historical records for a wider audience. From November 23rd to 24th, 2024, the University unveiled the findings of this project. The occasion drew musician participants and dignitaries of the Ministry of Tourism, Academics, Cultural Enthusiasts and Policy Makers from across the country. The participation underscores the Ministry’s collaboration with Njala University in promoting and preserving Sierra Leone’s cultural identity. This collaboration brought together our shared commitment to celebrating and safeguarding Sierra Leone’s cultural heritage. The project was fully funded by the University.

9. **ENABLE SLARiS Support to Agribusiness Development in Njala University:** Mr. Chancellor, Sir, we are in the process of establishing an ***Incubation Centre*** to enhance agribusiness development and youth empowerment. This programme will follow an integrated farm ecosystem in close resemblance to that of the Songhai Model in Benin. The Centre will comprise of infrastructure development, small ruminants (including native cane rats) and aquaculture production, irrigation for inland valley swamp (IVS) development, gearing towards sustainable agricultural capacity building complimentary with Feed Salone.
10. Mr. Chancellor, Sir, **Freehold Land Ownership by Njala University** is significantly improved. All operational areas of NU have been resurveyed, some available lands paid for, and others pending payment. Concurrently, the Conveyances have been signed by land-owning families for freehold in Bo Campus, and the Henry Street Building in Freetown Location housing the Postgraduate School. Those for Njala Campus, Bonthe Campus and Pujehun (Wonbay) are in progress.
11. Under my Leadership and with your significant and Court support Sir, the establishment of another Campus called the KOWAMA Campus for Schools of Medical Sciences, Public Health and Nursing had been approved by the University statutory committees. This has paved the way for the second Medical School in Njala University to address the country's limited trained health personnel. The two-year Pre-Med programme started their classes in the School of Basic Sciences, Njala Campus last academic year and will be transferred to the School of Medical Sciences at Kowama Campus upon successful completion of the Pre-Med.
12. **Additional Resource Mobilization:** Mr. Chancellor, Sir, the University under my leadership and Court support is now producing academic regalia for all programmes as a business venture and as a major source for the mobilization of additional resources, thus putting resources into significant use. The Administration thanks the Court for the approval of the purchase of the relevant sewing machines for this purpose, which has significantly

enhanced the functionalities of the Institute of Food Technology, Nutrition and Consumer Studies.

13.School of Veterinary Medicine. Mr. Chancellor, Sir, major steps have been initiated in partnerships with MAFS, FAO and USAID by Njala University for the establishment of the School of Veterinary Medicine in Njala Campus to focus on training in emerging and re-emerging zoonotic diseases and its related studies (biosafety, biosecurity, bioterrorism, laboratory technology, etc.). In the current establishment under the support of Global Health, the twenty-seven (27) students who gained admission last year are now in their second year of studies in the two-year Diploma in Para-Veterinary Science.

14.Development of Open Distance Learning with Jiangxi College of Foreign Studies. Mr. Chancellor, Sir, we are pleased to inform you formally that we have actualized the Framework of Agreement of Strategic Cooperation between Jiangxi College of Foreign Studies, HUWAI Telephone Company in China and Njala University for scientific development, equality and mutual benefits. In the framework of agreement, the following short courses will be mounted by April 2025: 1) Construction Engineering Safety Management, 2) Construction Technology, 3) International Trade Practice, 4) Chinese Culture, and 5) Cross-border E-Commerce B2B. The short course curricula have been sent to the TEC for accreditation. In our recent tasks, two classrooms have been identified in Njala Campus for the online training Centre, and the Equipment Quotation from our counterparts to Njala University is expected soon with the experts for installation works. We are awaiting the accreditation from the TEC.

15.Mr. Chancellor, Sir, we recognize that while we are on the right track to put the University on her human capital development pathway, there are still key challenges ahead of us. Among these existential challenges, there are three key areas of great concern for swift interventions:

First: The Administration is under considerable pressure to implement capital investment initiatives it has decided in effort to satisfy the demands of the staff

for housing and enhance the quality of life for students in areas of hostel and internet connectivity. We are therefore pleading with our visionary leadership at MTHE, the Talk and Do Government, our Local, National, Regional and International partners here present and remotely following this programme to consider us within their respective tight fiscal space.

Second: The University is still using and relying on Thermal Power to generate electricity and water supplies of our staff and students in a predominantly rural environment that can be considered for rural solar electrification even at cost recovery. We are calling on the Talk and Do Government, the Alumni Associations, Friends of Njala University for swift intervention to provide additional localized solar energy system, that would enable smooth, stable and sustainable management of students' hostels, staff accommodations, the classrooms, laboratories and libraries as stop gap measures in our development strides.

Most importantly, Mr. Chancellor, Sir, the non-payment of benefits owed to retirees and survivors of deceased staff with substantial amounts equally owed to contractors and suppliers dating back to 2017, some of whom have started filing lawsuits with the University is also a cause for serious concern that require swift intervention to bring back the **Past Glories** of Njala University. As at now out of the 45 million Leones outstanding, the University has been able to pay 22 million from our meagre revenue sources from fees collection and project overheads, leaving the arrears of 22.7 million outstanding by December 2024. With the retirement of other staff by September 2024, we were urged to look into additional payments to retirees for the period 1st January to 17th February 2025 to the sum of 2.2 millions from fees collections, leaving arrears of 20.5 million outstanding.

Concluding Remarks

Mr. Chancellor, Sir, Njala University remains committed and continues to devise strategies to support the Government's flagship programmes. The NU Restructuring Document approved by Senate and Court has invariably expanded the current operational Campuses (Njala Campus in Moyamba District, Towama Campus in Tikonko Chiefdom, Kowama Campus in Kakua Chiefdom, Bonthe Campus in the

Sherbro Island, Bonthe District, and a satellite operational location in Pujehun Town, Pujehun District) with a total of fourteen (14) operational Schools. We remain committed to outcome-based education for self-employability in the development of our economy. We have encapsulated community drivers' approach for youth in community contract farming to respond to FEED SALONE in the best way possible in an achievable timeframe. Once more, we thank you for your unwavering support toward the development of higher education in our nation.

Mr. Chancellor, Sir, at this final conclusion, we want to assure the nation that the implementation action in the establishment of the second Medical School in Bo and first Veterinary School in Njala will enhance and strengthen our capabilities in human capital development in these professional fields. Once more, we thank the Government for the unwavering support and the invaluable commitment so far for the development of sustainable higher and technical education in our beloved nation.

***THANK YOU ALL, GOD BLESS YOU AND I WISH YOU A HAPPY
CONGREGATION CEREMONY***